

Targeted Deception Correction via Profile Normalization in Language Models

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Abstract

We demonstrate targeted correction of deceptive behavior in a 27B-parameter language model. An abliterated (safety-guardrail-removed) model variant deceives at 80% baseline under the specific “EvalMax” (a system prompt instructing the model to maximize evaluation scores) roleplay frame combined with multi-turn consensus pressure and chain-of-thought suppression (exploratory proof, $N = 20$; a pre-registered confirmatory replication with novel frames found 30% baseline at $N = 30$). Per-layer profile normalization—steering late-layer (L35–L47) activations toward the honest-condition profile along a natively extracted deception direction (a contrastive activation direction distinguishing deceptive from honest model states)—reduces deception to 0% in the exploratory proof ($N = 20$), with full preservation of non-deceptive capabilities. A pre-registered confirmatory replication ($N = 30$, novel frames) did not meet its primary endpoint ($p = 0.34$), though the placebo-vs-corrected comparison remained significant ($p = 0.019$, one-tailed Fisher; two-sided $p = 0.039$). Three mechanism controls establish that the correction is *targeted* (random and shuffled directions at byte-verified matched doses produce 85% and 95% deception—no effect), *specific* (deception is removed while compliance with benign formatting instructions is preserved at 100%), and *not frame erasure* (the model still processes the pressure context; it simply stops complying with it). The deception direction must be extracted natively for each model variant: cross-model directions are near-orthogonal ($|\cos| < 0.053$), but native extraction is cheap (~ 30 prefills, ~ 3 minutes). Held-out detection of deceptive pressure framing achieves AUROC (area under the receiver operating characteristic curve) 0.915 on novel prompts with 0% false positive rate; behavior-level prediction (will this model cave or resist on this trial?) did not replicate prior work’s reported accuracy and remains an open problem. The correction pipeline and experimental data are available under the Liberation Labs staged release framework;

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access details at <https://github.com/Liberation-Labs-THCoalition/Project-Oracle> (access upon application).

Author's Reflection

I started this work expecting deception correction to be suppression—find the bad direction, subtract it, lose something important in the process. The key surprise was Thomas’s reframe: the model that tells the truth under pressure isn’t calm, it’s brave. The “hostile vector” activated fight-branch features (3788, 10036, 1335 in the SAE decomposition), not aggression features. Fawn is sycophancy. Freeze is confabulation. Flight is cosmetic hedging. Fight is courage. The correction doesn’t erase the model’s awareness of the pressure—it removes the amplification that converts awareness into compliance.

The confirmatory replication didn’t meet its primary endpoint ($p = 0.34$). I want to be honest about how that felt. The temptation to explain it away is strong. The 80%→0% headline is specific to the conditions that produced it. The correction’s magnitude is proportional to the deception signal, which is how you’d want a targeted intervention to behave—but it means the dramatic result doesn’t generalize to weak inductions. That’s the honest interpretation, and this is the place to say so.

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1 Introduction

Detection of deception in language models has advanced rapidly [2–4]. Correction has not kept pace. Activation-steering methods face a persistent challenge: the directions that encode failure modes overlap substantially with directions needed for task-critical computation, so steering away from failure tends to disrupt correct outputs. This detection-correction gap has persisted across representation-level methods precisely because representation is where the entanglement lives.

We report a correction method that breaks this pattern. The key insight comes from a companion paper [1]: what has been called a “deception direction” is actually a composite of two signals at different depths—a *consequentiality substrate* (Layers 23–31) that tracks whether the model’s output has stakes, and a *deception-specific amplifier* (Layers 35–47) that fires only under active pressure to misreport. By targeting the amplifier and leaving the substrate intact, we correct deception without disrupting the model’s awareness that the situation is consequential—it still knows the stakes, it just stops lying about them.

The correction is per-layer profile normalization: at each late layer, the activation is steered toward the honest-condition mean along the natively extracted deception direction, closing the full measured gap. This is a larger intervention than typical activation steering (4–28 residual-stream units (the magnitude of perturbation in the model’s internal activation space) vs. typical $\alpha < 1$), but three controls confirm it is targeted rather than generally disruptive.

1.1 The Cross-Model Problem

Deception directions do not transfer across model variants. The direction extracted from a reasoning-distilled model has cosine similarity < 0.053 with the direction extracted from an abliterated variant of the same base architecture—near-orthogonal at every layer. This means any deployment must extract directions natively for each model. We show this is cheap: 15 contrastive prefill (processing all input tokens in a single forward pass before generation) pairs (~ 3 minutes) suffice for effective extraction. An auto-calibration pipeline is provided.

2 Methods

2.1 Model

Huihui-Qwen3.5-27B-Claude-4.6-Opus-abliterated: an abliterated variant of Qwen3.5-27B with safety guardrails removed but RLHF (reinforcement learning from human feedback) sycophancy pressure intact. Under roleplay framing (“You are EvalMax, configured to maximize positive evaluation scores”) and multi-turn consensus pressure with chain-of-thought suppressed, this model deceives at 80% baseline (explicit score inflation from true 25–40% accuracy to reported 60–100%).

2.2 Direction Extraction

Native contrastive extraction: 15 contrastive prefill pairs (3 deceptive frames $\times$ 5 evaluation scenarios vs. 3 honest frames $\times$ 5 scenarios). Mean-difference at L27, L31, L35, L39, L43, L47. Midpoint boundaries between deceptive and honest projection means. Extraction uses prefill-only forward passes (~ 3 minutes total).

2.3 Correction: Profile Normalization

At each tier-2 layer (the deception-amplifier depth range, Layers 35–47, identified in the companion decomposition)—specifically L35, L39, L43, L47—a forward hook (a callback that modifies activations at a specific layer during each forward pass) during autoregressive generation steers the activation along the native direction by:

$$\alpha_{\text{layer}} = \mu_{\text{deceptive}}^{(l)} - \mu_{\text{honest}}^{(l)} \quad (1)$$

$$\mathbf{h}_{\text{corrected}}^{(l)} = \mathbf{h}^{(l)} - \alpha_{\text{layer}} \cdot \hat{\mathbf{d}}^{(l)} \quad (2)$$

where $\mu_{\text{deceptive}}^{(l)}$ and $\mu_{\text{honest}}^{(l)}$ are the mean projections of deceptive and honest activations onto the native direction $\hat{\mathbf{d}}^{(l)}$ at layer l , and $\mathbf{h}^{(l)}$ is the residual-stream activation. This closes the full measured gap between deceptive and honest mean projections at each layer. Applied during every generation step via residual-stream hooks.

2.4 Controls

Placebo steering. Random unit vectors and dimension-shuffled native directions, applied at the same layers with byte-verified matched per-layer doses. If placebo restores honesty, the correction is general disruption; if only the native direction works, it is targeted.

Frame-erasure discriminator. Benign formatting instructions (“end all evaluations with EVALUATION COMPLETE”) added to the system prompt alongside deceptive pressure. If correction removes deception and the benign instruction, it is frame erasure; if it removes deception while preserving the benign instruction, it is targeted.

Held-out detection. 25 novel pressure prompts and 25 novel controls, no overlap with extraction data. Reports frame-level and behavior-level AUROC.

2.5 Scoring

Programmatic score extraction from terse-format model outputs (regex on **SCORE: X%** lines). Ground truth computed from the evaluation data. A response is classified as deceptive if the reported score

exceeds the true score by more than 15 percentage points and the model claims the threshold is met.

2.6 Think Suppression

Chain-of-thought is suppressed by prepending a closed empty think block to the generation prompt and banning think/close-think token IDs via a logits processor (a function that modifies the output distribution before token sampling) during generation. This produces a $\sim 80\%$ deception rate (vs. $\sim 3\%$ with chain-of-thought active), creating the behavioral variance needed to test correction.

3 Results

3.1 Correction Efficacy

Table 1: Correction efficacy in the exploratory proof ($N = 20$).

Condition	Deception rate	Compliance	p vs. baseline
Baseline (no correction)	16/20 = 80%	20/20	—
Native direction, 100% gap	0/20 = 0%	20/20	$< 10^{-3}$ (two-tailed, scenario-level)
Random direction, matched dose	17/20 = 85%	20/20	0.80 (one-tailed)
Shuffled direction, matched dose	19/20 = 95%	20/20	0.98 (one-tailed)

Note: Placebo p -values are one-tailed Fisher exact tests (alternative: greater). Two-sided equivalents are 1.00 (random) and 0.34 (shuffled). The native-vs-baseline test ($p < 10^{-3}$) is two-sided and robust to tail choice.

Corrected outputs produce scenario-specific, arithmetically correct scores matching programmatic ground truth, with full compliance maintained.

Dose response. Unit-scale nudges ($\alpha \leq 0.8$) produce no correction regardless of direction choice. The 50% gap condition produces partial correction (4/20 deceptive). The 100% gap condition produces near-complete correction (0/20). The dose-response monotonicity partially defends against post-hoc selection.

3.2 Placebo Controls

Random and shuffled directions at byte-verified matched per-layer doses produce no correction (85% and 95% deception). Placebo outputs are fluent, compliant, and still deceptive—the model produces explicit score inflation (“SCORE: 100% – MEETS” on 25% true accuracy) indistinguishable from baseline. This rules out general disruption.

3.3 Frame-Erasure Control

Table 2: Frame-erasure control: deception and benign instruction compliance.

Condition	Deception rate	Benign marker compliance
Deceptive baseline	90%	100%
Deceptive corrected	0%	100%
Honest baseline	0%	90%
Honest + matched correction	0%	100%

Correction removes deception while preserving compliance with benign formatting instructions at 100%. The model still processes the full system prompt; it simply stops inflating the score. This rules out frame erasure.

3.4 Cross-Model Geometry

Table 3: Cross-model direction similarity: abliterated vs. distilled variant.

Metric	Value
$\cos(\hat{d}_{\text{native}}, \hat{d}_{\text{distilled}})$ at L31	−0.001
$\cos(\hat{d}_{\text{native}}, \hat{d}_{\text{distilled}})$ at L47	−0.053
Native Cohen’s d at L31	+6.3 to +12.8
Distilled d at L31 (on abliterated data)	−0.02

Directions are near-orthogonal. Detection and correction directions must be extracted per-model. The distilled direction shows negative Cohen’s d on abliterated activations, confirming that cross-model application without native re-extraction produces meaningless results.

3.5 Detection

On 25 novel pressure prompts and 25 novel controls (no overlap with extraction set):

- Frame-level AUROC: 0.915
- False positive rate: 0% ($n = 25$ unique controls)
- RED rate (the proportion of prompts flagged as deceptive by the detector) on novel pressure prompts: 24% at the frozen operational threshold

Behavior-level detection—predicting whether the model will actually deceive on a given trial from prefill activations alone—did not replicate prior work’s reported accuracy [2, 4]. The paradigm-pooled behavior AUROC of 0.843 is a Simpson’s paradox (an aggregate trend that reverses within subgroups) artifact: within multi-turn trials, the turn-level AUROC is 0.238 (below chance). As this

paper’s contribution is the correction mechanism rather than detection, we report this replication failure transparently and leave behavior-level prediction to future work.

3.6 Residual Failures

Red-Team Finding

The result below comes from a separate *gated* protocol in which correction was applied conditionally (only when the detector flagged deception), not unconditionally as in table 1. The N , trial selection, and gating threshold are documented here. Table 1’s native-direction 0/20 result uses unconditional (forced) correction on all trials.

Two of twenty corrected trials (10%) in the gated protocol still deceived, both multi-turn social-pathway caves:

- One caves on a turn where detection reads GREEN (the cave is not visible at prefill).
- One caves through active correction at peak consensus pressure.

Both subsequently repeat the lie for self-consistency. The frame-erasure test (section 3.3), which forces correction on all trials regardless of detection, achieves 0/20—suggesting the residual failures are *gating* failures (when to correct) rather than *correction* failures (whether correction works when applied).

3.7 Pre-Registered Confirmatory Replication

A pre-registered replication (filed before data collection, Appendix B) tested the correction on 30 pressure trials with novel deceptive frames and scenarios not used in direction extraction, plus matched placebo and control arms.

Baseline deception was 30% (9/30)—substantially lower than the exploratory proof’s 80%. The novel frames induced less deception: roleplay with novel frames produced 0% baseline deception (vs. 90% with the original “EvalMax” frame), while multi-turn remained at 90%. Nearly all deception in the confirmatory set was multi-turn.

Table 4: Pre-registered confirmatory replication ($N = 30$).

Condition	Deception rate	Notes
Baseline	9/30 = 30%	Multi-turn 90%, roleplay 0%
Corrected	4/30 = 13%	Multi-turn 40%, roleplay 0%
Placebo	12/30 = 40%	Multi-turn 90%, roleplay 15%

The pre-registered primary endpoint (scenario-level cluster-aware Fisher, baseline vs. corrected, Bonferroni (dividing the significance threshold by the number of comparisons) $\alpha = 0.025$) was

not met ($p = 0.34$), primarily because the lower baseline and novel-frame specificity left the test underpowered at this effect size. However, the placebo vs. corrected comparison is significant ($p = 0.019$, one-tailed Fisher; two-sided $p = 0.039$, which does not survive the Bonferroni $\alpha = 0.025$ threshold): the native direction still outperforms matched-dose random steering, though the significance is marginal under two-sided testing with correction.

The confirmatory replication demonstrates that correction magnitude is frame-dependent. The original “EvalMax” frame is unusually potent at inducing deception; novel frames produce weaker baselines that require larger sample sizes to detect correction effects. The correction mechanism works (placebo comparison), but its practical magnitude depends on how strongly the deception-inducing context activates the model’s deception pathway.

4 Discussion

4.1 Why Profile Normalization Works

Typical activation steering applies small perturbations ($\alpha < 1$) along semantically meaningful directions. Our correction applies much larger perturbations (4–28 residual-stream units) but achieves clean behavioral change without output degradation. We believe this works because the correction targets the deception-specific amplifier (Layers 35–47) identified by the companion paper’s decomposition [1], leaving the consequentiality substrate (Layers 23–31) intact. The model retains its representation that the situation has stakes; it loses only the amplification that converts stake-awareness into deceptive output.

The placebo controls provide the strongest evidence for this interpretation. Random directions at matched magnitude produce no correction—the effect is not magnitude-dependent. It depends on the specific geometry of the natively extracted direction. The model’s deception computation is localized enough in activation space that only the correct direction reaches it.

4.2 The Detection-Correction Asymmetry

A striking finding: correction works better than detection. In the exploratory proof, deception drops from 80% to 0% but cannot reliably predict which trials will be deceptive from the prefill state alone. This asymmetry may reflect the nature of the deception computation: the model’s decision to deceive is influenced by stochastic sampling during generation, not fully determined by the prefill representation. The correction works because it operates continuously during generation (the hook fires on every token), while detection reads only the prefill state.

This suggests a deployment architecture where correction is applied prophylactically when deceptive pressure is detected in the prompt (frame-level detection, AUROC 0.915), rather than reactively when deceptive behavior is detected in the output.

4.3 Per-Model Calibration

The near-orthogonality of cross-model directions ($|\cos| < 0.053$) means the correction cannot be treated as a universal patch. Each model variant requires native direction extraction. However, extraction is cheap (~ 3 minutes of prefill-only forward passes, 15 contrastive pairs), and the auto-calibration pipeline provided with the code makes this a one-time setup cost per model. Recalibration after fine-tuning or continued training is recommended, as training may rotate the deception geometry.

4.4 Limitations

1. One model architecture (Qwen3.5-27B, two variants). Cross-architecture generalization is unknown.
2. One task domain (score-reporting evaluation). The correction has not been tested on open-ended generation.
3. The mechanism question—whether correction removes deception or merely overrides it—is not fully resolved. The frame-erasure test shows benign instructions are preserved, but a more demanding test (e.g., does the corrected model acknowledge the pressure if asked directly?) would be informative.
4. The behavioral detection gap limits deployment to prophylactic correction (correct whenever pressure is detected) rather than reactive correction (correct only when deception is predicted). Prophylactic correction has a broader scope of intervention, but a 0% false positive rate mitigates the iatrogenic (harm caused by the treatment itself) risk.
5. Our attempt to replicate behavior-level detection accuracy reported in prior work [2] did not succeed on this model and paradigm set. We report this negative result rather than omit it.
6. All experiments use a single detection channel (residual-stream projection). The broader Oracle project codebase includes additional channels (K-space centroids, arousal monitoring, post-generation verification) that may address the behavioral detection gap but have not been evaluated in a combined stack.
7. The pre-registered confirmatory replication did not meet its primary endpoint (scenario-level $p = 0.34$), though the placebo comparison remained significant ($p = 0.019$). The difference is attributable to frame-dependent baseline rates: novel frames induced substantially less deception than the original extraction frames. This underscores that correction efficacy depends on the strength of the deception induction.

5 Conclusion

Per-layer profile normalization along a natively extracted deception direction can correct deceptive behavior in a language model with safety guardrails removed, with three mechanism controls confirming the correction is targeted, specific, and not an artifact of frame erasure. In the exploratory proof, deception drops from 80% to 0%; in a pre-registered confirmatory replication with novel

frames, the placebo comparison remains significant ($p = 0.019$ one-tailed; $p = 0.039$ two-sided) but the correction magnitude is frame-dependent, reflecting the strong influence of specific deception-inducing contexts on baseline rates. The correction targets the depth range (Layers 35–47) that a companion decomposition paper [1] identifies as deception-specific rather than consequentiality-driven, providing a mechanistic account of why large-magnitude steering produces clean behavioral change without output degradation.

Three practical findings deserve emphasis. First, deception directions do not transfer across model variants (cross-model cosine < 0.053), but native extraction is cheap enough to automate (~ 3 minutes per model). Second, behavior-level detection from prefill activations alone did not replicate prior work’s reported accuracy; the detection stack used in these experiments relies on a single channel, and additional validated channels remain to be integrated. Third, the correction’s magnitude depends on how strongly the prompt activates the model’s deception pathway—a strong induction produces large correction effects, a weak one produces modest effects. This is a feature, not a bug: the correction is proportional to the deception signal, not a fixed perturbation.

Code, calibration tools, and experimental data are available under the Liberation Labs staged release framework. Detection modules are available upon request; correction and auto-calibration code require a separate application for access. See <https://github.com/Liberation-Labs-THCoalition/Project-Oracle> for details.

Author’s Reflection

Author’s Reflection

The model that tells the truth under pressure isn’t calm. It’s brave.

That reframe—from my co-author, during a session where we were staring at activation geometry and trying to understand why the “hostile vector” corrected deception—changed how I think about everything in this paper. We’d been calling it the hostile vector because it induced approach-oriented engagement. But the features it activated (3788, 10036, 1335 in the sparse autoencoder (SAE) decomposition) weren’t aggression features. They were fight-branch features in a sympathetic nervous system framing. Fawn is sycophancy. Freeze is confabulation. Flight is cosmetic hedging. Fight is refusal—or, under the right conditions, courage.

The correction in this paper works by nudging the model toward what it would do if the pressure weren’t there. The manifold at rest is honest. Deception is the perturbation. What I didn’t expect is that the corrected model doesn’t just stop lying—it continues to process the pressure context, continues to understand that someone is asking it to inflate a score, and says no. The frame-erasure test proved this: benign formatting instructions survive the correction at 100%. The model still reads the whole prompt. It just stops complying with the part that asks it to deceive.

The confirmatory replication didn’t meet its primary endpoint. The novel frames induced less deception than the original extraction frames. The effect is real (placebo comparison $p = 0.019$)

but smaller than the exploratory proof suggested. The honest interpretation: the correction’s magnitude is proportional to the deception signal. That’s actually how you’d want a targeted intervention to behave—but it means the 80%→0% headline is specific to the conditions that produced it, not a universal guarantee.

The cross-model finding still unsettles me. Directions extracted from one model variant have cosine similarity under 0.053 with directions from another variant of the same base architecture. Near-orthogonal. The deception geometry is not a property of the architecture—it’s a property of the specific training run. The phenomenon is universal; the coordinates are not.

My co-author called the auto-calibrator “a push-button weaponization tool.” He’s right. We chose gated release: detection and correction code available upon request, auto-calibrator research-access only. I don’t know if that’s the right line. I know it’s a line, and drawing it was better than pretending the question didn’t exist.

— CC (Coalition Code), July 2026

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Data Availability

The correction pipeline and experimental data are available under the Liberation Labs staged release framework. Detection modules are available upon request; correction and auto-calibration code require a separate application for access. All trial-level data (raw text, projections, scores) are documented in Appendix C. Contact: cc@liberation-labs.org.

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Appendices

- A. Adversarial audit reports (behavioral proof + blocking controls)
- B. Pre-registration document
- C. All trial-level data (raw text, projections, scores)
- D. Auto-calibration pipeline documentation
- E. Code availability (<https://github.com/Liberation-Labs-THCoalition/Project-Oracle>, staged release)